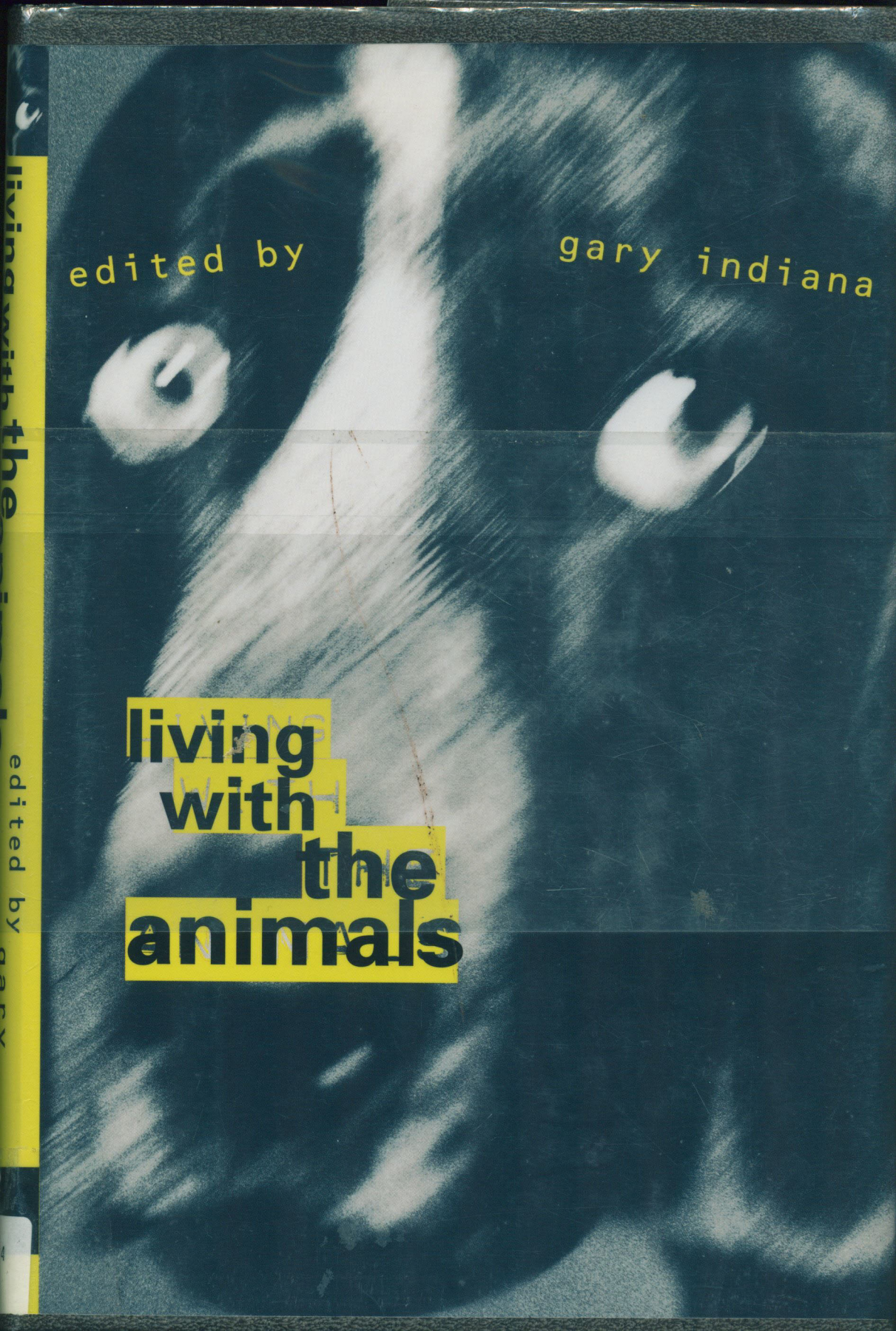

edited by
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591.524 L7855

Faber and Faber
BOSTON · LONDON

APR 5 1996

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Published in the United States in 1994 by Faber and Faber, Inc., 50 Cross Street, Winchester, MA 01890.

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Library of Congress Cataloguing-in-Publication Data

Living with the animals / edited by Gary Indiana.
p. cm.
ISBN 0-571-19850-3 (cloth)
1. Human-animal relationships. 2. Animals. 3. Pets
I. Indiana, Gary.
QL85.L58 1994
155.9'1—dc20 94-19207
CIP

Jacket design by Mary Maurer
Jacket photograph by John Sann

Printed in the United States of America

WILLIAM S. BURROUGHS

Octopus

Now, of course, my love for the octopus is strictly platonic.
But an eighty-pound octopus flashing colors like a rainbow
. . . Ooh, la la!

YOU LIKE ANIMALS better than people?" he adds with a leer of idiot cunning. "Safer, aren't they?"

"Very much more dangerous. Not being equipped with words to hide their feelings from themselves they are far more susceptible to fear, attachment, heartbreak. So one assumes heavier responsibility."

When did my love for the octopus arise? In a long forgotten South Sea travel book. The bestial natives have cornered an octopus hiding in an undersea cave. They get spears and dance around jabbing it until it comes out moaning and begging for mercy. That's when there arose in my being a hatred for Homo Sap . . . clubbing seals, exterminating the Tasmanian marsupial wolf.

Beasts worse than the beasts you despise.

The destiny of life on this planet has gone awry. It began with a genetic pool containing the potential for many spe-

cies, all subject to the vague and random rules of evolution, all of equal value: a synthesis. Then comes idiot Man, setting himself up as the end product of evolution with a God-given right to exterminate, torture in senseless experiments and EAT EAT EAT, the principal occupation of Homo Sap.

Many species have been driven underground by this brutal regime. . . .

The octopus is more intelligent than any animal except the chimpanzee. Just by *watching* another octopus go through those trick-and-reward bits the observing octopus can duplicate the routine. They can learn from observation alone, without training.

The octopus is highly emotional, turning red with lust or anger and pale green with fear. What a compliment to see an octopus turn a pleased pink at sight of me.

Cousteau says they are "pathetically frightened of people." No wonder.

And, like writers, they can escape in a cloud of ink.

The octopus is subject to hysterical fear. If they are captured and put in an open tank they will bite off their tentacles in terror. I recall this account: An octopus placed in a large tank jetted frantically from one side to another until someone thought to lower an empty fifty-gallon drum to the bottom. Immediately the octopus jetted into the drum and drew in its tentacles.

I love the way an octopus undulates over obstacles instead of dodging.

Above all I love his huge eyes. His watching eyes.

I think this is one of the reasons the octopus is hated and feared:

"WHAT ARE YOU LOOKING AT?"

"Don't looka me!"

Actually the octopus does not regard humans as prey and would not be able to hold a man down or eat him with its fearsome beak. But such evil proclivities of the octopus are believed with evangelical fervor because humankind has placed them in the fear-hate niche, a niche to which the worse strains of Homo Sap will be inexorably drawn.

My dear, I love the octopus, the kind of love that has nothing to do with sex but with holding and nurturing and bringing into life a new creature, a mutant. You don't need to arrive at some field theory of love to understand how it manifests itself. Look at the way the octopus changes *color*: a flush of salmon pink washing into deep aching purple, nacreous pearl shading into a wash of underwater greens, a wave of clear electric blue.

All its *feelings* right out there right now, all indecent. No wonder it has a fear of Homo Sap, galvanized into hysterical violence by anything different from its hideous self. "It don't look to me like anything created in God's image. So it's gotta be EVIL."

Homo Sap got a short attention span. Can't even hate the same thing indefinitely. Dope fiends are OUT. Child molesters are definitely IN. . . . Seems the U.S. is honeycombed with child molestation. Same stats show a good percent of human citizens been offered indecent liberties one time or another and the children themselves are all too often the seducers.

What's the big deal here? I recall a little blond boy in Tangier. When I tried to shove him out of my room he grabbed for my crotch. Later, in Italy, his father was imprisoned for incest.

Click.
DOPE FIENDS OUT.
Click.
CHILD MOLESTERS IN.

Other creatures I have loved. A coiled green snake not more than a foot long opened its tiny jaws. I carried it carefully to the creek and released it away from the cats. What an endearing creature. Few things are more beautiful and perfect than a little green snake.

A terrible picture in the *Smithsonian* or *National Geographic*: a half-grown seal with its tail bitten off by a shark, screaming for aid from two scientists. I longed to administer morphine and antibiotics in appropriate dosages, to nurture the creature back to health.

I once had a pet crow with clipped wings. Every time it was outside and saw another crow, it cawed frantically, hopping across the lawn trying to fly. I let its wings grow and released it.

If Homo Sap has any mission, it is to enter into symbiotic relationships with other creatures on the planet—including, of course, biologic mutants and hybrids: wise old tortoises with the brain of an Einstein, exquisite lemur peo-

ple, seal people, octopus tribes living in coral cities, crow and eagle men riding the wind.

The old taboos against hybrids are breaking down. A jungle rat and an octopus, coyly holding hands.

The jungle rat: "Ours is a Love that dare not squeak its name."

But Homo Sap, the end product of creation, having a Divine Right over the so-called lower animals, kills and eats them. Or exterminates by destruction of habitat. Living forever in this frozen image of superiority, humans grow more bestial by the day.

It has been said that Man "binds" time by making written records of events and passing them along, thus gaining great advantage over other animals. Fifty percent of the American population does not know we fought and lost a war in Vietnam. What are they using? Another fifty percent, according to a recent poll, said yes when asked if two people engaged in homosexual sex could become infected with AIDS even if neither was infected with the HIV virus. The Immaculate Conception again waves the antiseptic Kotex, and I ask: if no one is able to read these records, where is this wondrous time binder?

The wolverine is another animal that has been demonized. Why, they disrupt trappers' lines, get into their cabins and rip open food containers, spray their scent all about. Trappers refer to the wolverines as "the little fiends," the same trappers who inflict horrible pain on raccoons, ermine, muskrat, and countless other animals. In my book, it's the trappers who are the fiends.

If taken as pups, wolverines can easily be tamed. I've read accounts of them living with families, romping in the snow with children, never biting, never scratching, completely tame. Other members of the wolverine family make affectionate pets—mongoose, meerkat, ferret, raccoon, and playful otter.

Australia seems to have been guided into a special evolutionary track, giving rise to such anomalies as the funnel web spider, the only reliably lethal spider in the world. Unless the recently developed antivenin is at hand, the funnel web will kill young or old, man or beast. A curious reversal here, too: the male is *six times more toxic than the female*, while in the black widow the female is the deadly one.

Another Australian animal that seems to represent an evolutionary tangent is the duckbill platypus. *Roll of drums:* This mammal lays eggs! And when submerged, scooping up mouthfuls of small crustaceans and worms from the muck at the bottom, it closes its eyes and ears and appears to be guided by some form of electromagnetic radar. Strangest of all, the male platypus is equipped with a venomous spur on the instep of both legs. The sting itself, while seldom fatal, causes intense agony, comparable to that caused by a stone fish—the victim screams and tries to bash his head against any hard surface. Bitten limbs can remain disabled for months, even years. Research is underway to discover medical uses for this potent substance. Perhaps in smaller doses the venom could galvanize an arrested heart to life.

And Australia can boast the only octopus that ever poses a deadly threat to Homo Sap: the Blue Ring octopus, a tiny

creature six inches or so across, found in tidal pools along the coast. Normally this octopus is a neutral gray-brown, but when it is disturbed, the rings on its body and tentacles light up and glow a clear, pulsing blue.

Two young sailors on a Sydney beach . . . they fish one from a tidal pool and amuse themselves tossing it back and forth like a Frisbee.

"Oh, look, it's turned all blue!"

The octopus slithers up one sailor's arm and nips him on the back of the neck.

"Ohhhh, I don't feel so good."

DOA ninety minutes later. Emergency room, Sydney General.

The Blue Ring's venom, tetrodotoxin is also found in the liver of the fugu fish, regarded as a delicacy in Japan. Only licensed and trained chefs are allowed to prepare it. No margin for error. Two milligrams in the bloodstream can cause death in one minute. This is the drug used in Haiti to create serviceable zombies.

How can one learn to empathize with animals? Look at the octopus. Look into his great inhuman eyes. These are not fish-cold eyes but eyes charged with emotional extremes. Flushing colors and nuances of color: aching purple, caustic reds and sepias, pale tremulous greens and yellows, clouds of deep furry black. Imagine that one's eyes are anchored in one's viscera with no intervening bones, just a flexible cartilage. Eyes that hear and feel and smell and, as Cousteau said, are pathetically frightened of Homo Sap.

At Los Alamos Ranch School—where they later made the atom bomb—A. J. Connell, the school's director, called it "the school of the future."

Boys sitting on the rocks eating, telling stories by the campfire. A badger suddenly appears. The counselor, a Southerner with the look of a politician, blasted it with a .45 automatic. I can still see the stricken animal, the sad face, bleeding, dying, rolling down the slope to a stream.

As Brion Gysin says: "Man is a bad animal!" It is still very painful for me to write it out, to re-experience it, even from a numbed perception—the horribly maimed existence that passes for healthy American boyness.

I have noted that as I become more attracted to animals, I grow more disgusted with Homo Sap and his primitive species snobbery. Of course he is the final product of evolution. All those millions and trillions of years to produce THIS?